

TRANSFORMATION

Exercise is the most common reason why people first come to yoga. However, the spiritual side of yoga often becomes more important for those who continue to practice. With advances in technology including neuroimaging, researchers are now exploring yoga's potentially transformative spiritual effects.

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*Neuroscientists are now studying the **brain** during spiritual states.*

Q WHAT ARE THE SPIRITUAL STATES THAT ANCIENT YOGIS SPOKE OF?

The “**eight limbs**” of yoga are outlined in an ancient text called the “Yoga Sutras.” The first four limbs concern how we live in the external world, and are intended to prepare your body and mind for the second four, which concern our internal world or consciousness (see below).

Astronauts undergo a similar process to the eight limbs of yoga: from an ethical code to intensive physical

exercises to prepare the body and mind. When in space, “Earth gazing” is reportedly so captivating that astronauts spend hours just staring at the planet. This can be seen as similar to yogic concentration (dharana) exercises, such as staring at the flame of a candle to improve concentration and eventually evoke higher states of consciousness.

According to a 2016 paper called “The Overview Effect: Awe and Self-Transcendent Experience in Space Flight,” astronauts return to Earth with a new perspective and sense of purpose. The founder of Phoenix Rising Yoga Therapy, Michael Lee, believes we can experience the same transformation on Earth by exploring the last four limbs of yoga.



THE EIGHT LIMBS OF YOGA

The ultimate aim of the eight limbs of yoga is to help us live a meaningful life. Not all modern classes incorporate them, but many at least allude to this depth and potential.